FREE FROM MINDFULGAMING.ORG

Mindful Gaming Starter Pack

Printable pages to start playing with purpose, playing well, and playing together.

- The three Mindful Gaming questions
- A complete session from *The Mindful Gaming Journal* (print as many as you like)
- Five Side Quests
- A session and Word Bank page from *The Feelings Are Real*
- Conversation starters for parents

Jeff Swift, PhD
Author of *Mindful Gaming*

WHAT MINDFUL GAMING IS

Better, not less

Mindfulness means paying attention to what's happening right now, on purpose and without judging it. Mindful gaming brings that same attention to the games you already play.

It rests on three questions you can ask yourself before, during, and after any session:

1 PLAY WITH PURPOSE

Why am I gaming right now?

2 PLAY WELL

How do I want to play today?

3 PLAY TOGETHER

Who am I gaming with?

WHAT IT IS

- Choosing your play instead of drifting into it.
- Noticing the feelings that come with winning and losing, and learning from them.
- Seeing the people in your play, from teammates to the parent on the couch.

WHAT IT ISN'T

- A screen-time tracker or a way to make you quit.
- A judgment about which games are "good" or "bad."
- Therapy. It's a practice, like a training log for an athlete.

Pre-Session Check-In

STRETCH 1 · PURPOSE — GETTING CLEAR ON WHY YOU PLAY

Date: _____ Game(s): _____

1 PLAY WITH PURPOSE

Why am I gaming right now?

CHECK WHAT APPLIES TODAY

- ☐ Relax
- ☐ Achieve a goal
- ☐ Overcome a challenge
- ☐ Beat a personal record
- ☐ Connect with someone
- ☐ Learn something new
- ☐ Level up / grind
- ☐ Build something

Today I'm most looking forward to:

_____

_____

2 PLAY WELL

How do I want to play today?

MY MOOD RIGHT NOW

- ○ Joy
- ○ Trust
- ○ Fear
- ○ Surprise
- ○ Sadness
- ○ Disgust
- ○ Anger
- ○ Anticipation

If today gets frustrating, what will help me reset?

_____

_____

3 PLAY TOGETHER

Who am I gaming with?

- ☐ Solo
- ☐ Friends I know
- ☐ People online
- ☐ Family

One thing I hope happens today:

_____

LEVEL TIP · SESSION 1

Any purpose counts. "To relax" is just as real as "to rank up." The point is to choose it instead of drifting into it.

In-Session Check-In

Remember your three questions: Why am I gaming? How do I want to play? Who am I gaming with?

PAUSE CHECK · RIGHT NOW I FEEL

○ Joy ○ Trust ○ Fear ○ Surprise
○ Sadness ○ Disgust ○ Anger ○ Anticipation

STILL MATCHES MY PURPOSE FROM TODAY?

☐ Yes ☐ Kind of ☐ Not really

What am I working on right now?

BIG MOMENT (IF ANY)

What just happened, and where do I feel it in my body?

WHAT DO I NEED RIGHT NOW?

☐ A break ☐ Keep going ☐ Someone to talk to

TIME CHECK

Started at: _____ Planned stop: _____

How will I know it's time to wrap up?

Post-Session Reflection

1 PLAY WITH PURPOSE

Did today match my purpose?

COMPARED TO MY PLAN, GAMING TODAY WAS

☐ What I hoped for ☐ Kind of ☐ Not really

What did I spend most of my time on today?

Hardest thing I tried, and what I learned:

2 PLAY WELL

How did I feel while playing?

HOW I FEEL NOW

◯ Joy ◯ Trust ◯ Fear ◯ Surprise

◯ Sadness ◯ Disgust ◯ Anger ◯ Anticipation

COMPARED TO WHEN I STARTED, MY MOOD IS

☐ Better ☐ About the same ☐ Worse

Something that went well, and one thing I can carry into real life:

SKILLS I NOTICED MYSELF USING TODAY

☐ Patience ☐ Resilience

☐ Problem solving ☐ Handling frustration

☐ Creativity ☐ Teamwork

☐ Goal-setting ☐ Emotional intelligence

Post-Session Reflection (cont.)

3 **PLAY TOGETHER**

Who was part of today's session?

☐ Solo ☐ Friends I know ☐ People online ☐ Family

A moment I felt connected with someone:

Something I noticed about how someone else played:

OVERALL, TODAY FELT LIKE...

RATE TODAY'S SESSION

◯ Rough ◯ Not great ◯ Okay ◯ Good ◯ Great

One thing to remember before I play again:

Anything else on your mind:

BONUS

Side Quests

Five short quests that map to the three pillars. Try one at a time, whenever you want a change from the regular check-ins.

1 · PLAY WITH PURPOSE

The Purpose Check Naming a purpose before playing turns autopilot into intention.

Why am I gaming right now?

What game am I about to play?

What would make this session feel worthwhile afterward?

2 · PLAY WITH PURPOSE

The Failure Log Failure is one of gaming's most consistent feedback systems. Naming it turns it into a skill.

What I was trying to do:

What went wrong:

What I'll try differently:

3 · PLAY WELL

The Emotion Scan The games are fake. The feelings are real.

I felt:

I felt it in my body here:

I did this with that feeling:

4 · PLAY WELL

The Reappraisal Looking back on what you learned locks it in and makes the next session better.

One thing I got better at today:

One thing I'd try differently next time:

5 · PLAY TOGETHER

The Co-Op Invite Nothing builds connection faster than letting someone into your world.

Invite a parent, sibling, or friend to watch you play for 10 minutes. Then let them ask: What's the goal of the game you're playing?

What's the hardest thing you've done in this game?

What do you think this game makes you good at?

REFERENCE

My Word Bank

Add every gaming-feeling word you catch, written the way you actually say it. Fill in the family in Phase 3. Mark double agents (words that fit more than one family) with ◐.

MY WORD	WHEN I SAY IT	FAMILY	◐

Before You Play

SESSION 1 · FIRST LOOK

Date: _____ Game: _____

1 PLAY WITH PURPOSE

Why am I gaming right now?

- ☐ Relax
- ☐ Have fun with someone
- ☐ Win / rank up
- ☐ Get better
- ☐ Explore / story
- ☐ Build / create
- ☐ Pass the time
- ☐ Other: ___

2 PLAY WELL

How's my energy right now?

○ Low ○ Steady ○ Wired ○ Not sure

3 PLAY TOGETHER

Who am I gaming with?

- ☐ Solo
- ☐ Friends I know
- ☐ Online players
- ☐ Family
- ☐ My team / squad

TODAY'S WATCH

During the first big moment of today's game (a win, a loss, a close call), notice what your body does. Don't name a feeling yet. Just notice.

COACH'S NOTE

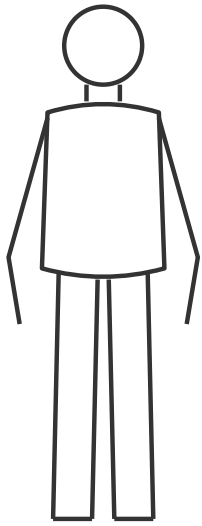
Your body usually notices a feeling before your brain finds a word for it. That's why this journal starts with the body.

Right before I play, my body feels:

_____

After You Play

TODAY'S WORK



Mark where you felt it

CIRCLE WHAT IT FELT LIKE

tight · loose · hot · cold · fast · slow · heavy · light · shaky · buzzing · clenched · fluttery · numb · still

OTHER WORDS FOR IT

The moment I noticed:

What happened right before it:

How strong? (1) (2) (3) (4) (5) 1 = barely · 5 = huge

OFF THE SCREEN

Notice one moment outside of games today (school, home, practice) when your body reacted. What did it do?

BANK IT

New cue I noticed: _____ (Phase 4 will use these)

FOR PARENTS AND CAREGIVERS

Conversation starters

Adapted from *Mindful Gaming*. Pick one, not all of them. Ask when the game is paused, not mid-match.

PURPOSE

- What are you working on in the game you're playing?
- What strategies have you been wanting to try next time?
- What does it feel like when you need a break from playing?

FEELINGS

- How do you feel when you make a mistake in a game? When you succeed?
- When you're gaming, where do you feel big emotions in your body?
- What can you do next when a game makes you really frustrated?

SKILLS

- What do you think this game makes you good at?
- Tell me about the hardest thing you've ever done in a game. What did you learn?
- Is there somewhere outside of games where that skill could help?

TOGETHER

- Who's your favorite person to play with? Why?
- What's most frustrating about gaming with other people? Most rewarding?
- If you could teach me one game, which would you choose?

WANT THE FULL JOURNALS?

Keep going

The Mindful Gaming Journal
47 guided sessions with a Level Tip each time, field guides, Pattern Checks, and a parent guide. Paperback on Amazon.

The Feelings Are Real
A 52-session journal that helps young gamers notice, name, and handle big emotions, with five badges to unlock. Paperback on Amazon.

Mindful Gaming: A Guide for Parents of Young Gamers
The book behind the framework.

You're on the list. About twice a month you'll get one short, practical email: a question to ask your gamer, a skill to watch for, or a new free page. Unsubscribe any time.

You may print and copy these pages for your own family, classroom, or practice. Please don't resell or repost them. © 2026 Jeffrey Swift · mindfulgaming.org

Psychoeducational, not a substitute for professional care. In the U.S., call or text 988 for the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.